



path. If the 2024 victory was a tribute to then skipper Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli, the ageing heroes, the champagne moment in 2026 was all about revealing an India that was muscular, intimidating and a relentless six-hitting machine.

While sitting next to captain Suryakumar and holding the trophy, Gambhir told the media: "I would rather we play a high-risk game instead of being conservative, and in that bid, if we finish at times with 120, so be it. Same with batters — you are on 94 or 96, would you take singles for your hundred or try to hit a four? Because remember, the respect you get for a 97 in the dressing room would be the same as for a 100."

And none reflected this philosophy more than Samson. Not part of the initial plans when the team settled into the campaign, the opener was ushered in to break the tedium of three left-handers atop the batting tree. Right-handed Samson promptly did everything right.

His unbeaten 97 against West

Blue supremacy: In the blue shade, India remains the team to beat, especially in T20Is. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Indies at Kolkata is one of the finest T20I knocks played by an Indian. He followed that up with an 89 against England in the semifinal at Mumbai and another 89 in the final.

Abhishek, blighted with three ducks at the start, eventually registered two fifties, with the one in the climax against New Zealand being vital. Ishan and Tilak Varma had their runs too but, more importantly, Dube the batter was more impressive than in his regular skill-set of bowling.

This duality in performances of many players kept India in good stead. Axar Patel's (**left**) catching effort during the semifinal against England was from the top drawer. And stars were found in every game. Mohammed Siraj was rushed in to play the opener against the United States of America (USA) and he immediately delivered a three-for spell. The Hyderabad-based bowler had no further